trades. In a mere generation, producers became importers of grains and vegetables. The state now sends drinking water tankers to villages on Khadir Island, and has put a reverse osmosis filtration plant in Dholavira village for the brackish groundwater. The output is then sold at one rupee per litre. The villagers hope that the state will buy them an Israeli mobile desalination unit to make 100,000 litres of drinking water per day from the brackish groundwater. Others dream of a canal from the Narmada River, whose water already doesn't reach the sea. This seems like the future in most of Kutch, India's largest district. No one seems to be inspired by the ancient Dholaviran approach to this problem.

The Harappan Imagination

What was the unique genius, or at least what were the most distinctive qualities, of Harappan versus other early civilizations? 'The Indus polity and Indus society look totally unlike their contemporary equivalents in Mesopotamia,' writes Andrew Robinson in *The Indus: Lost Civilizations* (2015). Unlike in Mesopotamia and Egypt, archaeologists have not found any military grade weapons or war damage in Harappan cities, nor any depictions of war, armies or prisoners on Harappan seals or pottery, which otherwise depict a large range of subjects, including real and mythical fauna, flora, symbols, bullock carts, hunting scenes, people wearing jewels and elaborate headdresses, and mother goddess figures. This apparent lack of a warring culture is often attributed to their lucky geography—tucked between the north-western mountains, the eastern desert and the southern sea—which, it is said, shielded them from external enemies.

The Harappans, apparently, did not even wage internal wars. This is often explained by saying that the riverine Harappan cities were well provisioned, with no scarcity of food or other resources, reducing the impetus for conflict. However, Parpola believes that violence likely accompanied major transitions, as from the early to the mature Harappan phase, though there is no hard evidence (some early Harappan sites have turned up ash and debris, which may have resulted from either violent or accidental fires). Indeed, an *entirely* peaceful civilization is an idle fantasy, and Occam's razor points to other conclusions. After all, most cities had thick walls with watch towers.